

Sequential Structure in Near-Death Experience

Evaluating the Normative Path Model

NDE Research Project

Structured Data Analysis Repository

<https://github.com/kayna-of-light/structured-data-analysis>

October 6, 2026

Correction notice (2026-10-06). The canonical stage order tested in §3.8 (OBE, tunnel, light, encounters, review, boundary, return) is the extraction schema's, taken from the NDE literature. It is not Swedenborg's sequence, which is three *states* in the world of spirits — outward, inward, preparation — that “some people . . . do not go through” at all (*Heaven and Hell* §491). The result (strict order 0.05%) stands as data, but it is no longer scored as a miss of the framework; it is not a test of it.

Correction notice (2026-10-05). This report was revised after a statistical audit (docs/STATISTICAL_AUDIT_2026-10.md). Changes: (1) the sequence data the title refers to had never been analysed; they are now reported, and a fixed canonical order is essentially absent; (2) the life-review “15.9:1 loving:harsh” mixed life reviews with judgments recorded outside life reviews and used all 6,753 records as denominator — within life reviews the ratio is 36.2:1 but loving:critical is 1.7:1; (3) several percentages were computed on the wrong denominator (e.g. judgment sources as % of all NDEs); (4) the “four markers support” conclusion relied on criteria that could not fail; markers are now classified by what they can and cannot test; (5) agency $\times$ willingness χ^2 was inflated by co-missing data (4,824.8 $\rightarrow$ 1,389.0 without “not mentioned”); (6) N is 6,751 after removing two duplicate narratives, and four IANDS records previously mislabelled as NDERF are corrected. The LaTeX and PDF versions were regenerated from this corrected text.

Reliability addendum (2026-10-06). Coding reliability was measured with a blind second coder; see *Reliability of Near-Death Experience Narrative Coding* (08_extraction_reliability.ipynb). The presence of tunnel, light, life review and boundary, the elements this report sequences, agrees at Cohen's $\kappa = 0.77$ –0.97. The life-review loving:harsh ratio is coder-dependent: 36.2:1 under GPT-5.2, 6.4:1 (95% CI 3.1–43.9) under the second coder. Loving:critical (1.72 vs 1.77) is stable.

Abstract

Near-death experiences are often described as following a characteristic sequence — passage, arrival in light, encounters, life review, return. The Swedenborgian framework proposes a normative path in which most souls continue in the spiritual world, with reincarnation an exception. We analysed 6,751 NDE records from NDERF (n=5,659) and IANDS (n=1,092), coded with GPT-5.2 structured extraction, for return patterns, encounters with deceased relatives, identity, life review, reincarnation indicators, transformation, and adherence to a canonical stage order.

Among accounts stating who decided the return, 70.1% did not return by their own choice

(95% CI 68.8–71.4); among those stating their attitude, 49.4% were reluctant. Deceased relatives appeared in 17.9% of NDEs; identity was described as clear in 97.0% of accounts addressing it. Reincarnation content was rare: past-life memory 4.4%, intermission memory 1.0%, pre-incarnation covenant 1.3%. Life reviews occurred in 17.5%; within them, harsh evaluation was rare (1.4% of rated reviews) but uncomfortable evaluation common (28.0%). Strict adherence to the canonical stage order occurred in 3 of 6,249 assessable accounts (0.05%); 37.7% followed it mostly and 54.3% partially.

The data are consistent with several descriptive expectations of a continuation model — a valued state, encounters with the dead, preserved identity, rare reincarnation content, non-condemning review — but most of these markers do not discriminate between continuation and competing accounts. A characteristic sequence of episode elements is only weakly present; that sequence comes from the NDE literature, not from Swedenborg, whose sequence is of three states in the world of spirits that some people skip (*Heaven and Hell* §491).

Data Provenance

Item	Source	Access
NDERF Records (n=5,659)	Near-Death Experience Research Foundation	nderf.org
IANDS Records (n=1,092)	International Association for Near-Death Studies	iands.org
Analysis Code	02_normative_path_ validation.ipynb	Repository
Data loader	scripts/nde_dataset.py	Repository
Structured Data	structured/*.json	Repository (6,753 files; 6,751 unique narratives)
Extraction Model	GPT-5.2 via Azure OpenAI	Azure OpenAI Service

1 Introduction

1.1 Background

Near-death experiences feature recognizable elements: out-of-body experiences, tunnel passage, light encounters, meetings with deceased relatives, life reviews and return decisions (Moody, 1975; Ring, 1980; Greyson, 2003). Ring’s original work described a five-stage progression. Whether such structure is inherent to the experience or imposed in retrospective narration remains debated.

1.2 Theoretical Framework

Swedenborg (1758) described a post-mortem journey through a “World of Spirits” in stages — an external stage, an internal stage of self-revelation, and instruction — culminating in a community matching the person’s ruling love. Continuation is normative; reincarnation, where it occurs, is an exception (restorative healing after traumatic death, or a volunteered mission). NDE return to one’s current body is distinct from reincarnation.

Predictions examined: experiencers who glimpse the spiritual state should value it (reluctance to return); deceased relatives should be encountered; reincarnation content should be uncommon; identity should persist; the life review should reveal rather than condemn; and — a prediction from the NDE literature rather than from the framework — the experience should show a characteristic sequence.

Swedenborg’s sequence is of states, not of episode elements: “there are three states that we pass through after death before we arrive in either heaven or hell . . . Some people, however, do not go through these states” (*Heaven and Hell* §491; tr. Dole). An NDE, which ends in return, reaches at most the threshold of the first. The canonical order coded in this dataset is the schema’s, derived from the NDE literature. §3.8 therefore tests a property of NDE narratives, not a prediction of the framework.

1.3 Aims and What Can Be Tested

Every member of the dataset returned and all data are retrospective self-reports. The analyses therefore describe return, encounter, identity and review phenomenology and assess whether each is consistent with the framework — and whether a competing model would predict something different. A marker that any model predicts equally is reported as *consistent, not a test*.

2 Methods

2.1 Data Sources

NDERF (5,659 records) and IANDS (1,092 records); two duplicate narratives counted once (N = 6,751). Source is taken from the records' dataset field.

2.2 Fields

Return agency (self, external_being, involuntary, mutual) and willingness (willing, reluctant, mixed, neutral); return reasons (multi-select: earthly mission, family responsibility, not your time, unfinished business, other); deceased relatives; identity continuity; reincarnation and pre-birth indicators (explicit or implied); life review occurrence, judgment source, judgment intensity and experiencer emotional tone; before/after death fear, spirituality and religiosity; and stage-sequence fields (canonical_sequence: strict / mostly / partial / radical; repeated and simultaneous stages).

2.3 Statistical Analysis

Proportions with Wilson 95% CIs and stated denominators ("not mentioned" excluded where indicated). χ^2 tests with expected-count checks and Cramér's V; Wilcoxon signed-rank tests for before/after changes on 5-level scales; exact binomial CIs for ratios.

3 Results

3.1 Return Agency and Willingness

Return agency	n	% of stated (n = 4,781)
External being	1,930	40.4%
Involuntary	1,422	29.7%
Self	1,124	23.5%
Mutual	305	6.4%
Not mentioned	1,970	—

70.1% (95% CI 68.8–71.4) of stated returns were not self-chosen. Of 3,563 accounts stating an attitude, 49.4% were reluctant, 26.5% mixed, 21.4% willing and 2.7% neutral.

Agency and willingness are strongly associated among accounts stating both (n = 3,330; $\chi^2 = 1,389.0$, df = 9, $p < 10^{-290}$, Cramér's V = 0.37). Of those sent back by a being, 73.3% were reluctant and 6.0%

willing; of those who chose to return, 53.2% were willing and 10.4% reluctant. (The previously reported $\chi^2 = 4,824.8$ included “not mentioned” categories; 1,737 records lack both.)

Finding: most stated returns were not self-chosen, and reluctance is common. *Interpretation:* reluctance shows the NDE state was valued; it is consistent with the framework but would also follow from any intensely pleasant altered state, so it does not discriminate between models. “Return as exception” is untestable because everyone in the dataset returned.

3.2 Return Reasons

Not your time 21.6%, family responsibility 17.2%, unfinished business 10.5%, earthly mission 9.2%, other 3.2% (of all NDEs; 44.3% gave at least one reason). The schema has no “personal preference” category, so the earlier statement that “duty and obligation rather than preference drive return” cannot be tested from this field; 557 experiencers both chose to return and were willing.

3.3 Deceased Relatives

Deceased relatives were encountered in 1,206 NDEs: 17.9% of all (95% CI 17.0–18.8) and 22.6% of accounts that address the question (named 1,007, unnamed 199).

Finding: consistent with continuation, **not a test.** The data contain no measure of how long relatives had been dead, and several reincarnation doctrines also allow encounters with the recently dead in an intermediate state, so no competing quantitative prediction is available.

3.4 Identity

Identity was described as clear in 4,376 of 4,511 accounts addressing it (97.0%, 95% CI 96.5–97.5); altered or lost in 92 and confused in 43.

Finding: strongly consistent with persistence of identity, but preserved selfhood is also predicted by non-survival accounts of NDE phenomenology; it does not discriminate between them.

3.5 Reincarnation Indicators

Indicator (explicit or implied)	n	% of all	95% CI	% of accounts addressing it
Premortal existence information	478	7.1%	6.5–7.7	9.5%
Past-life memory	297	4.4%	3.9–4.9	6.2%
Chose mission	140	2.1%	1.8–2.4	3.0%
Pre-birth realm description	120	1.8%	1.5–2.1	2.6%
Pre-incarnation covenant	86	1.3%	1.0–1.6	1.9%

Indicator (explicit or implied)	n	% of all	95% CI	% of accounts addressing it
Chose life circumstances	82	1.2%	1.0–1.5	1.8%
Intermission memory	69	1.0%	0.8–1.3	1.6%
Chose parents	29	0.4%	0.3–0.6	0.6%

(Earlier figures of 1.4% for chose mission and 0.1% for chose parents counted only “implied” responses.) Memory of a prior death appears in 36 accounts (19 violent).

Finding: reincarnation content is **rarely reported** in NDEs. This is consistent with reincarnation as an exception but **not a test** of it: absence of a report during a brief NDE is not evidence of absence of prior lives, and no competing model predicts a specific higher rate. The earlier rule “supported if below 10%” could not fail.

3.6 Life Review

Life reviews occurred in 1,183 NDEs (17.5%, 95% CI 16.6–18.4; brief 718, extensive 465).

Evaluator (928 reviews with stated source): none 53.1%, guide or entity 19.9%, Being of Light 15.9%, self 10.2%, deceased relative 0.8%. About a third (36.6%) involved an external evaluator. (The earlier report gave these as percentages of all 6,753 records, including records without a life review.)

Character (428 rated reviews): loving/gentle 50.7% (95% CI 46.0–55.4), neutral 19.9%, uncomfortable 28.0% (24.0–32.5), harsh/condemning 1.4% (0.6–3.0). Loving : harsh = 36.2 : 1 (95% CI 16.3–99.6); loving : (uncomfortable + harsh) = 1.72 : 1. A blind second coder rated more reviews harsh. Reweighted to these 428 reviews, its harsh share is 8.7% (1.3–16.8) and loving : harsh is 6.4 : 1 (3.1–43.9), while loving : critical is 1.77 : 1. The loving : critical ratio is the coder-robust summary. Judgment fields are also filled for 26 records without a life review (8 of them harsh); the earlier 15.9 : 1 (223 : 14) mixed both groups.

Empathetic perspective (feeling others’ emotions): 18.0% of life reviews (previously reported as 2.9% of all NDEs). **Experiencer tone:** mixed is most common; love (163) and shame/regret (169) are about equally frequent.

Finding: the life review is predominantly **non-condemning** (harsh $\approx 1\%$), in line with Swedenborg’s description of self-revelation rather than punishment. It is not uniformly loving: more than a quarter of rated evaluations are uncomfortable, and experiencers feel regret as often as love.

3.7 Transformation

Where both levels are stated: death fear fell in 84.7% and rose in 4.0% ($n = 327$; mean $2.43 \rightarrow 0.31$ on 0–4; Wilcoxon $p < 10^{-45}$); spirituality rose in 83.7% and fell in 1.7% ($n = 723$; $p < 10^{-100}$); religiosity

rose in 20.2% and fell in 19.9% ($n = 1,168$; $p = 0.58$). Death fear “after” is stated in 1,402 accounts but “before” in only 569, so the pairs are selected toward people whose fear changed.

3.8 Sequential Structure

Canonical stage order	n	% of assessable ($n = 6,249$)
Strict	3	0.05%
Mostly	2,356	37.7%
Partial	3,396	54.3%
Radical departure	494	7.9%

Stages were repeated in 23.1% and simultaneous in 43.8% of accounts addressing these questions. Stage elements present: return decision 83.5%, OBE 65.6%, environment 56.8%, light 55.8%, communication 54.9%, boundary 40.6%, tunnel 32.9%, loved ones 21.4%, life review 15.2%.

Finding: NDE elements recur as a recognisable *set*, but not in a fixed *sequence*. A strict temporal ordering is **not observed**. This does not count against Swedenborg’s account, whose sequence is of states in the world of spirits rather than of episode elements (§1.2). It counts against the common description of the NDE as a fixed passage through stages.

4 Discussion

4.1 Evidence Assessment

Marker	Corrected value	What it can show	Assessment
Return not self-chosen	70.1% of stated	Everyone returned; “exception” untestable	Consistent, not a test
Reluctance to return	49.4% of stated	State was valued; not model-discriminating	Consistent, not a test
Deceased relatives	17.9%	No competing quantitative prediction	Consistent, not a test
Identity preserved	97.0% of stated	Predicted by most models	Consistent
Reincarnation content rare	1–4%	Absence of report $\neq$ absence of prior life	Consistent, not a test
Life review non-condemning	Harsh 1.4%, uncomfortable 28.0%	Framework predicts revelation over condemnation	Supported (harsh rare); “loving” overstated
Canonical sequence	Strict 0.05%, mostly 37.7%	Tests the literature’s episode order, not the framework’s sequence of states	Not observed as a strict order; not a framework prediction

4.2 The Threefold Path Framework

The data are compatible with a normative path of continuation with rare exceptions, in the sense that reincarnation and pre-birth content are uncommon (1–7%). They cannot establish the relative frequencies of the three paths: NDE reports describe what is experienced during a brief episode, not soul histories. The 4.4% reporting past-life memory and the 1–2% reporting pre-incarnation choices are rates of *reported content*, not estimates of how many experiencers are on restorative or volunteer paths.

4.3 The World of Spirits as Transition Zone

NDE phenomenology shares several features with Swedenborg’s account of the World of Spirits: encounters with the dead, preserved identity, a self-revealing review that is rarely condemning, and instruction or guidance. These parallels are real in the data. Two cautions: the parallels are mostly with features that many afterlife models share, and the weak canonical ordering of episode elements does not bear on Swedenborg’s sequence of states, which an NDE reaches only at its threshold.

4.4 Clinical Implications

The low rate of harsh evaluation in life reviews ($\approx 1\%$) may be reassuring to people who fear judgment at death. Clinicians should also know that uncomfortable evaluation and feelings of regret are common parts of the life review, and that experiencers who were sent back against their wishes frequently report reluctance — validating both aspects supports integration.

4.5 Limitations

Self-selected online archives; LLM extraction (inter-coder κ 0.77–0.97 for the sequence elements; judgment intensity unstable at the harsh boundary); retrospective reports; many fields “not mentioned”; before/after pairs selected toward change; predominantly Western sample (country stated for 12%).

4.6 Future Directions

Pre-registered, discriminating predictions (e.g. what a reincarnation-normative model would predict about deceased-relative encounters as a function of time since death); human-validated coding of stage order; and comparison with prospective clinical NDE samples.

5 Conclusion

Across 6,751 near-death experiences, return is usually not self-chosen and often reluctant, deceased relatives appear in about one in six accounts, identity is preserved, reincarnation content is rare, and the life review is predominantly non-condemning though often uncomfortable. These findings are consistent with a continuation model of the post-mortem path, but most do not discriminate it from alternatives. The characteristic episode order described in the NDE literature is weak: strict canonical order is essentially absent. That order is not Swedenborg’s sequence, which concerns states in the world of spirits (*Heaven and Hell* §491). The earlier conclusion of “convergent support” from “four markers” overstated what these data can show.

References

Greyson, B. (2003). Incidence and correlates of near-death experiences in a cardiac care unit. *General Hospital Psychiatry*, 25(4), 269–276.

Moody, R. A. (1975). *Life After Life*. Mockingbird Books.

Ring, K. (1980). *Life at Death: A Scientific Investigation of the Near-Death Experience*. Coward, McCann & Geoghegan.

Swedenborg, E. (1758). *Heaven and Hell* (G. F. Dole, Trans.). Swedenborg Foundation.

A Statistical Summary

Test	Statistic	df	p-value
Agency × willingness (both stated)	$\chi^2 = 1,389.0, V = 0.37$	9	$< 10^{-290}$
Death fear before vs after	Wilcoxon W = 1,148 (n = 327)	—	$< 10^{-45}$
Spirituality before vs after	Wilcoxon W = 2,198 (n = 723)	—	$< 10^{-100}$
Religiosity before vs after	Wilcoxon W = 53,538 (n = 1,168)	—	0.58
Life review loving : harsh	217 : 6 = 36.2 : 1 (95% CI 16.3–99.6); second coder 6.4 : 1 (3.1–43.9)	—	—
Life review loving : critical	217 : 126 = 1.72 : 1	—	—

B Key Statistics

Metric	Value
Total NDEs analyzed	6,751
Return not self-chosen (of stated)	70.1%
Reluctant to return (of stated)	49.4%
Deceased relatives present	17.9%
Identity clear (of stated)	97.0%
Past-life memory	4.4%
Pre-incarnation covenant	1.3%
Life review occurred	17.5%
Harsh / uncomfortable evaluation (rated reviews)	1.4% / 28.0%
Strict / mostly canonical sequence	0.05% / 37.7%

C Data Access

- **Repository:** <https://github.com/kayna-of-light/structured-data-analysis>
- **NDE Project:** [/tree/main/projects/nde/](#)
- **Analysis Notebook:** [02_normative_path_validation.ipynb](#)
- **Audit:** [projects/nde/docs/STATISTICAL_AUDIT_2026-10.md](#)